

Time Out

Callison Hustles—'When It Counts'

By ALLEN LEWIS

JOHAN CALLISON hit a routine fly ball to right field in a recent game against the Chicago Cubs. The Phillies were one run behind and there were two out in the eighth inning. Callison started out at a trot for first base and not until he rounded the bag did he run hard.

Asked about the play later, Callison, who looks as serious as an undertaker until he smiles, grinned a little sheepishly. "I know what you mean," he said. "I guess I was mad at myself for going hitless and I didn't run hard. About the time I got to first I thought to myself, 'You better get going, or he'll let you know about it.'"

The "he" Callison referred to was Manager Gene Mauch, who made a better player of himself by hustling.

Before the Phils' next game, Mauch stopped by Callison's locker and made reference to the play in a half-joking way, but he got his point across.

"That son-of-a-gun," Callison said, after Mauch walked away. "He never misses a thing. He won't have to tell me about that again."

Callison has played pro baseball only four years and passed his 21st birthday just last March. Fairly or unfairly, he has already acquired the reputation of one who is inclined to "dog" it when things aren't going well. Is this a bad rap? "I think I hustle," Callison said, "at least when it means something."

MAUCH, who watched Callison play for almost two years on a rival team in the American Association, agrees. So does Andy Cohen, who piloted Denver when Calli-

son was starring for Indianapolis.

"I think he hustles," Mauch said. "He's young yet, and once in a while he forgets, but he bears down when it means something. You can have those guys that do all their running back and forth to their positions. That doesn't mean a thing. Give me the ones that put out when it counts."

Callison's biggest problem may be the fact that he is blessed with so much natural talent he quickly becomes dissatisfied with himself when he fails to do as well as he thinks he should.

They tell of the time in September, 1958, shortly after the Chicago White Sox had recalled him from Indianapolis. It was a windy afternoon in Comiskey Park and the nearest thing to a hurricane was blowing in from right field when Callison ripped into a fast ball and smacked it to the wall for a triple. Until then no one had hit one to within 50 feet of the wall that day.

At the end of the inning, Callison came in to the dugout, shaking his head. "I hit that ball as hard as I could," he said, "and I still couldn't get it into the seats."

Coach Johnny Cooney's mouth opened in amazement. "Son, are you serious?" he said. "Without that wind that ball would have landed a block away."

Callison played little more than half a season in Class C after graduating from East Bakersfield (Calif.) High School in 1957, where he was an all-around athlete. He did so well that year the Sox decided to jump him to Indianapolis in the spring of 1958.

CHUCK COMISKEY, then Chicago's vice-president, called John into his office, told him he was being promoted and asked, "Do you think you can make the jump from Class C to Triple A?"

"Mr. Comiskey," Callison replied, "I can play any place you send me."

He did, too, playing 154 games, batting .283 and hitting

29 homers, a remarkable figure for a 175-pounder who appears deceptively small.

Callison exudes confidence, but he's by no means the smart-alecky type. He simply believes in his own ability, especially when he's swinging a bat.

Callison, who has a classic swing, has convinced every baseball man who has seen him play about his power. One American Association first baseman found out about it first hand in 1958. John hit a scorching line drive that bounced off the guy's mitt, hit him on the head and knocked him groggy.

"And I didn't even get a hit on the play," Callison recalled. "The ball bounced right to the second baseman on the fly, and all I got was a big at-bat."



JOHN CALLISON



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to create
today's
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